INFOGRAPHIC · TIM MARSHALL, PRISONERS OF GEOGRAPHY

# China's development vs Africa

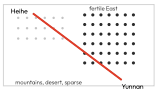
Two geographies, two outcomes: one concentrates people, farmland and security into a fortress heartland; the other divides them with barriers nature and empire left behind.

China  Africa · Ghana

## 01 · China — secured by its geography

*"A great power now confident that it is secured by its geographical features."* — p. 52

### 01 Agriculture + geographical features




> *"This imaginary line is probably the most important geographical feature in this country"* PP. 53–54

China's heartland is "the political, cultural, demographic and crucially the agricultural centre of gravity". The Hu Line, from Heihe to Yunnan, explains the disparity of China's population: the fertile east is densely populated, the west is not....

**SIGNIFICANCE.** The most important factor: a great power now confident that it is secured by its geographical features.

### 02 Borders + buffer zones




> *"It wants a buffer zone in the border regions to protect it from instability"* P. —

China's large expanse means it borders many countries, so it wants buffer zones to protect it from instability and secure it early. The buffers deter invaders, which makes it easier to focus on non-militaristic sectors. This is a by-product of...

**SIGNIFICANCE.** Security bought by the buffers frees money for development, but at the cost of unrest in the border regions.

### 03 Naval exploits + sea navigation




> *"A green-water navy patrols its maritime borders"* P. —

A green-water navy patrols China's maritime borders — now the world's largest navy. Through the Nine-Dash Line China claims almost the whole of the South China Sea. That lets it divide countries, control trade routes, access resource...

**SIGNIFICANCE.** The sea extends China's secure core outwards into trade, resources and jobs — a step Africa has never been able to take.

## The comparison — why does one develop faster?

SIMILARITIES

**Geography first**

Both are continental-scale regions whose fate was set by geography before politics. Both live with buffers and borders they did not choose, and both face pressure from fast-growing populations on limited farmland.

DIFFERENCES

**One core vs many splits**

China has one fertile, river-linked heartland walled in by mountains and desert, so it became a single centralised state. Africa's rivers are broken by waterfalls, its coast lacks harbours and its interior is split by desert and jungle.

WHICH WOULD BE BIGGER?

**Africa in area, China in use**

Africa is roughly three times China's land area and has a similar population today, with Africa's set to grow far faster. On size and resources Africa should be the giant; on connected, usable geography China is.

WHY DOES ONE DEVELOP FASTER?

**Unity was cheap**

China's geography concentrates people, food and power. Africa's disperses and obstructs, and imposed borders turned natural division into conflict. China's map made unity cheap; Africa's makes it expensive.

## 02 · Africa — prisoners of a geography they did not choose

*"Many Africans are now partially prisoners of the political geography the Europeans made, and of the natural barriers to progression with which nature endowed them."*

### 01 Natural barriers

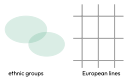



> *"These are just two in a long list of problems that help explain why Africa isn't as technologically or politically advanced"* P. 170

Africa's geography is a negative factor. Rivers broken by waterfalls and rapids are poor for transport, and the coast has few natural harbours. North and south are poorly connected. Trade and infrastructure are expensive to build...

**SIGNIFICANCE.** Geography as a whole is underestimated; it explains much of Africa's technological and political deficiency.

### 02 Borders drawn by colonialism + war




> *"Many Africans are now partially prisoners of the political geography the Europeans made, and of the natural barriers with which nature endowed them"* P. —

The borders were drawn by Europeans without respect for ethnic groups — Sudan and Somalia among them. That promotes violence, from "Africa's world war" in the Congo onwards, and therefore political, social and economic...

**SIGNIFICANCE.** Imposed borders turned natural division into permanent conflict, blocking the stable core that China enjoys.

### 03 Population growth




> *"One in four people will be African"* P. 217

Perhaps Africa's biggest challenge is population growth: within decades one in four people on Earth will be African — an extra billion people. The continent will need to adapt infrastructure and increase agricultural produce, but inevitabl...

**SIGNIFICANCE.** Inevitable disparity: many will live in slums, which overall hinders development.

Quotations from Tim Marshall, Prisoners of Geography. China pp. 52–54; Africa pp. 170, 217.

INFOGRAPHIC · TIM MARSHALL, PRISONERS OF GEOGRAPHY

# China's development vs Africa

Two geographies, two outcomes: one concentrates people, farmland and security into a fortress heartland; the other divides them with barriers nature and empire left behind.

**1/4**
of people will be African

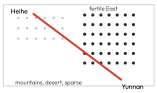
**3×**
Africa's land vs China

**No.1**
world's largest navy



Heartland · Buffers · Nine-Dash · Waterfalls · Colonial lines · 1 in 4

## 01 Agriculture + geographical features

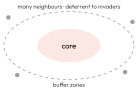



> *"This imaginary line is probably the most important geographical feature in this country"* PP. 53–54

China's heartland is "the political, cultural, demographic and crucially the agricultural centre of gravity". The Hu Line, from Heihe to Yunnan, explains the disparity of China's population: the fertile east is densely populated, the west is not....

**SIGNIFICANCE.** The most important factor: a great power now confident that it is secured by its geographical features.

## 02 Borders + buffer zones




> *"It wants a buffer zone in the border regions to protect it from instability"* P. —

China's large expanse means it borders many countries, so it wants buffer zones to protect it from instability and secure it early. The buffers deter invaders, which makes it easier to focus on non-militaristic sectors. This is a by-product of...

**SIGNIFICANCE.** Security bought by the buffers frees money for development, but at the cost of unrest in the border regions.

## 03 Naval exploits + sea navigation




> *"A green-water navy patrols its maritime borders"* P. —

A green-water navy patrols China's maritime borders — now the world's largest navy. Through the Nine-Dash Line China claims almost the whole of the South China Sea. That lets it divide countries, control trade routes, access resource...

**SIGNIFICANCE.** The sea extends China's secure core outwards into trade, resources and jobs — a step Africa has never been able to take.

---

SIMILARITIES

### Geography first

Both are continental-scale regions whose fate was set by geography before politics. Both live with buffers and borders they did not choose, and both face pressure from fast-growing populations on limited farmland.

DIFFERENCES

### One core vs many splits

China has one fertile, river-linked heartland walled in by mountains and desert, so it became a single centralised state. Africa's rivers are broken by waterfalls, its coast lacks harbours and its interior is split by desert and jungle.

WHICH WOULD BE BIGGER?

### Africa in area, China in use

Africa is roughly three times China's land area and has a similar population today, with Africa's set to grow far faster. On size and resources Africa should be the giant; on connected, usable geography China is.

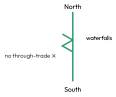
WHY DOES ONE DEVELOP FASTER?

### Unity was cheap

China's geography concentrates people, food and power. Africa's disperses and obstructs, and imposed borders turned natural division into conflict. China's map made unity cheap; Africa's makes it expensive.

---

## 01 Natural barriers

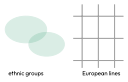



> *"These are just two in a long list of problems that help explain why Africa isn't as technologically or politically advanced"* P. 170

Africa's geography is a negative factor. Rivers broken by waterfalls and rapids are poor for transport, and the coast has few natural harbours. North and south are poorly connected. Trade and infrastructure are expensive to build...

**SIGNIFICANCE.** Geography as a whole is underestimated; it explains much of Africa's technological and political deficiency.

## 02 Borders drawn by colonialism + war




> *"Many Africans are now partially prisoners of the political geography the Europeans made, and of the natural barriers with which nature endowed them"* P. —

The borders were drawn by Europeans without respect for ethnic groups — Sudan and Somalia among them. That promotes violence, from "Africa's world war" in the Congo onwards, and therefore political, social and economic...

**SIGNIFICANCE.** Imposed borders turned natural division into permanent conflict, blocking the stable core that China enjoys.

## 03 Population growth




> *"One in four people will be African"* P. 217

Perhaps Africa's biggest challenge is population growth: within decades one in four people on Earth will be African — an extra billion people. The continent will need to adapt infrastructure and increase agricultural produce, but inevitabl...

**SIGNIFICANCE.** Inevitable disparity: many will live in slums, which overall hinders development.

---

Quotations from Tim Marshall, Prisoners of Geography. China pp. 52–54; Africa pp. 170, 217.

INFOGRAPHIC · TIM MARSHALL, PRISONERS OF GEOGRAPHY

# China's development vs Africa

Two geographies, two outcomes: one concentrates people, farmland and security into a fortress heartland; the other divides them with barriers nature and empire left behind.




01
**Hu Line**
fertile East

02
**3×**
Africa's area

03
**1 in 4**
will be African

VOL. 2 · THE SIX POINTS

## China

### 01 Agriculture + geographical features



> *"This imaginary line is probably the most important geographical feature in this country"* PP. 53–54

China's heartland is "the political, cultural, demographic and crucially the agricultural centre of gravity". The Hu Line, from Heihe to Yunnan, explains the disparity of China's population: the fertile east is densely populated, the…

**SIGNIFICANCE.** The most important factor: a great power now confident that it is secured by its geographical features.

### 02 Borders + buffer zones



> *"It wants a buffer zone in the border regions to protect it from instability"* P. —

China's large expanse means it borders many countries, so it wants buffer zones to protect it from instability and secure it early. The buffers deter invaders, which makes it easier to focus on non-militaristic sectors. This is a…

**SIGNIFICANCE.** Security bought by the buffers frees money for development, but at the cost of unrest in the border regions.

### 03 Naval exploits + sea navigation



> *"A green-water navy patrols its maritime borders"* P. —

A green-water navy patrols China's maritime borders — now the world's largest navy. Through the Nine-Dash Line China claims almost the whole of the South China Sea. That lets it divide countries, control trade routes, acces…

**SIGNIFICANCE.** The sea extends China's secure core outwards into trade, resources and jobs — a step Africa has never been able to take.

## Africa

### 01 Natural barriers



> *"These are just two in a long list of problems that help explain why Africa isn't as technologically or politically advanced"* P. 170

Africa's geography is a negative factor. Rivers broken by waterfalls and rapids are poor for transport, and the coast has few natural harbours. North and south are poorly connected. Trade and infrastructure are expensive to build…

**SIGNIFICANCE.** Geography as a whole is underestimated; it explains much of Africa's technological and political deficiency.

### 02 Borders drawn by colonialism + war



> *"Many Africans are now partially prisoners of the political geography the Europeans made, and of the natural barriers with which nature endowed them"* P. —

The borders were drawn by Europeans without respect for ethnic groups — Sudan and Somalia among them. That promotes violence, from "Africa's world war" in the Congo onwards, and therefore political, social and…

**SIGNIFICANCE.** Imposed borders turned natural division into permanent conflict, blocking the stable core that China enjoys.

### 03 Population growth




> *"One in four people will be African"* P. 217

Perhaps Africa's biggest challenge is population growth: within decades one in four people on Earth will be African — an extra billion people. The continent will need to adapt infrastructure and increase agricultural produce, but…

**SIGNIFICANCE.** Inevitable disparity: many will live in slums, which

SIMILARITIES

### Geography first

Both are continental-scale regions whose fate was set by geography before politics. Both live with buffers and borders they did not choose, and both face pressure from fast-growing populations on limited farmland.

DIFFERENCES

### One core vs many splits

China has one fertile, river-linked heartland walled in by mountains and desert, so it became a single centralised state. Africa's rivers are broken by waterfalls, its coast lacks harbours and its interior is split by desert and jungle.

WHICH WOULD BE BIGGER?

### Africa in area, China in use

Africa is roughly three times China's land area and has a similar population today, with Africa's set to grow far faster. On size and resources Africa should be the giant; on connected, usable geography China is.

WHY DOES ONE DEVELOP FASTER?

### Unity was cheap

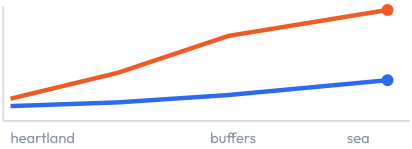
China's geography concentrates people, food and power. Africa's disperses and obstructs, and imposed borders turned natural division into conflict. China's map made unity cheap; Africa's makes it expensive.

Quotations from Tim Marshall, Prisoners of Geography. China pp. 52–54; Africa pp. 170, 217.

# China vs Africa Geography Report

Two geographies, two outcomes: one concentrates people, farmland and security into a fortress heartland; the other divides them with barriers nature and empire left behind.

### Overall geography




China concentrates a core, then extends it. Africa stays split.

### Population share




Within decades one in four people on Earth will be African. p. 217

### Usable geography




Africa is 3× the land; China has the connected, usable share.

### Sea vs land barriers




China's navy extends the core. Africa's coast lacks harbours.

### 01 Heartland & the Hu Line



China's heartland is "the political, cultural, demographic and crucially the agricultural centre of gravity". The Hu Line, from Heihe to Yunnan, explains the disparity of China's population: the fertile east is densely populated...

### 02 Borders & buffer zones



China's large expanse means it borders many countries, so it wants buffer zones to protect it from instability and secure it early. The buffers deter invaders, which makes it easier to focus on non-militaristic sectors. This is a by...

### 03 Navy & the South China Sea



A green-water navy patrols China's maritime borders — now the world's largest navy. Through the Nine-Dash Line China claims almost the whole of the South China Sea. That lets it divide countries, control trade routes,...

### 01 Natural barriers — a negative factor



Africa's geography is a negative factor. Rivers broken by waterfalls and rapids are poor for transport, and the coast has few natural harbours. North and south are poorly connected. Trade and infrastructure are...

### 02 Borders drawn by colonialism & war



The borders were drawn by Europeans without respect for ethnic groups — Sudan and Somalia among them. That promotes violence, from "Africa's world war" in the Congo onwards, and therefore political, social and...

### 03 Population growth



Perhaps Africa's biggest challenge is population growth: within decades one in four people on Earth will be African — an extra billion people. The continent will need to adapt infrastructure and increase agricultural...

**Similarities**

## Geography first

Both are continental-scale regions whose fate was set by geography before politics. Both live with buffers and...

**Differences**

## One core vs many splits

China has one fertile, river-linked heartland walled in by mountains and desert, so it became a single centralise...

**Which would be bigger?**

## Africa in area, China in use

Africa is roughly three times China's land area and has a similar population today, with Africa's set to grow far faster. On...

**Why does one develop faster?**

## Unity was cheap

China's geography concentrates people, food and power. Africa's disperses and obstructs, and imposed borders turned...

Quotations from Tim Marshall, Prisoners of Geography. China pp. 52–54; Africa pp. 170, 217.

# Development Progress Report

A visual representation of why one geography develops faster.

### China — secured by geography




A great power now confident that it is secured by its geographical features.

### Africa — prisoners of geography




Many Africans are now partially prisoners of the political geography the Europeans made, and of the natural barriers to progression with which nature endowed them.

### Project milestones

**01 Heartland & the Hu Line**

SECURED

The most important factor: a great power now confident that it is secured by its geographical features.

**02 Borders & buffer zones**

SECURED

Security bought by the buffers frees money for development, but at the cost of unrest in the border regions.

**03 Navy & the South China Sea**

SECURED

The sea extends China's secure core outwards into trade, resources and jobs — a step Africa has never been able to take.

**01 Natural barriers — a negative factor**

BLOCKED

Geography as a whole is underestimated; it explains much of Africa's technological and political deficiency.

**02 Borders drawn by colonialism & war**

BLOCKED

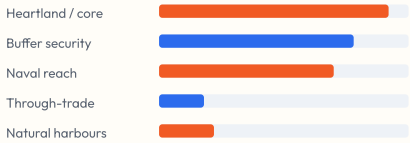
Imposed borders turned natural division into permanent conflict, blocking the stable core that China enjoys.

**03 Population growth**

RISING

Inevitable disparity: many will live in slums, which overall hinders development.

### Key performance




Heartland, buffers and navy vs rivers, harbours and borders.

### 1 in 4 people



**1 in 4**

an extra billion people

Africa's population challenge — p. 217

**Similarities**

## Geography first

Both are continental-scale regions whose fate was set by geography before politics. Both live with buffers…

**Differences**

## One core vs many splits

China has one fertile, river-linked heartland walled in by mountains and desert, so it became a single centralise…

**Which would be bigger?**

## Africa in area, China in use

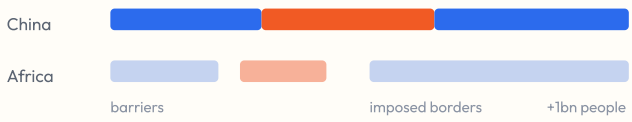
Africa is roughly three times China's land area and has a similar population today, with Africa's set to grow far…

**Why does one develop faster?**

## Unity was cheap

China's geography concentrates people, food and power. Africa's disperses and obstructs, and imposed…

### Projected vs actual timelines




Quotations from Tim Marshall, Prisoners of Geography. China pp. 52–54; Africa pp. 170, 217.

KEY INSIGHTS:

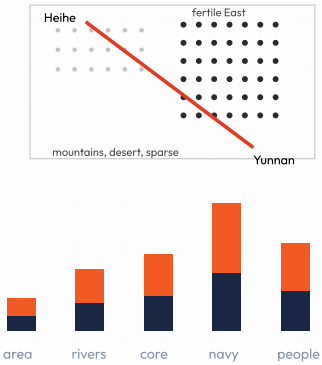
# GEOGRAPHY

Two geographies, two outcomes: one concentrates people, farmland and security into a fortress heartland; the other divides them with barriers nature and empire left behind.

## DATA 1

### Heartland & the Hu Line

China's heartland is "the political, cultural, demographic and crucially the agricultural centre of gravity". The Hu Line, from Heihe to Yunnan, explains the disparity of China's population: the fertile east is densely populated, the west is not. Terrain and climate concentrated people, food and power in one core.







## DATA 2

### Why one develops faster

China's geography concentrates people, food and power. Africa's disperses and obstructs, and imposed borders turned natural division into conflict. China's map made unity cheap; Africa's makes it expensive.

1. Geography first
2. One core vs splits
3. Africa bigger in area
4. Unity was cheap

## DATA 3

### Buffer ring and the navy

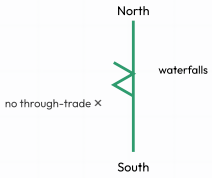
China's large expanse means it borders many countries, so it wants buffer zones to protect it from instability and secure it early. The buffers deter invaders, which makes it easier to focus on non-militaristic sectors. This is a by-product of the fertile east. Some of these regions are run as surveillance states, and the people living in them are unhappy. The sea extends China's secure core outwards into trade, resources and jobs — a step Africa has never been able to take.




## DATA 4

### Natural barriers — a negative factor

Africa's geography is a negative factor. Rivers broken by waterfalls and rapids are poor for transport, and the coast has few natural harbours. North and south are poorly connected. Trade and infrastructure are expensive to build around these barriers, in contrast to the Han heartland. Trade routes never developed.



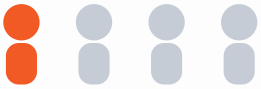

## DATA 5

### 1 in 4 will be African

Perhaps Africa's biggest challenge is population growth: within decades one in four people on Earth will be African — an extra billion people. The continent will need to adapt infrastructure and increase agricultural produce, but inevitably it cannot afford to. Political and religious clashes make it difficult to lower the bir...




1 in 4
will be African



**1 in 4**

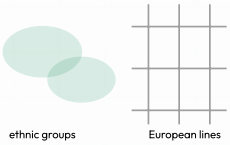
an extra billion people

## DATA 6

### Borders drawn by colonialism & war

The borders were drawn by Europeans without respect for ethnic groups — Sudan and Somalia among them. That promotes violence, from "Africa's world war" in the Congo onwards, and therefore political, social and economic instability. Contrast China's centralised core protected by buffer zones.






Quotations from Tim Marshall, Prisoners of Geography. China pp. 52–54; Africa pp. 170, 217.